

## An Artificer's Start

"Mama, where do babies come from?" As Aya asked the question, the gnome working on the floor did a double take. At a nearby table, Kira stifled a laugh; "Well, E? Where *do* babies come from?" The gnome looked uncomfortable for a brief moment, then her brow furrowed in concentration—a look that seemed very at home on her face.

"Well, you see, when a mommy and a daddy... uh, love each other... and they really want to start a family... they go through a special biological process called—" By this point, Kira burst out laughing. E's face flushed red, her concentration shattered.

"You are *adorable*, E. I'll take over from here." The elf walked over and knelt beside Aya. "Babies are a complicated little matter, and we'll explain it more when you're older. For now, all you need to know is that it's not the same for every species, but usually, it happens as a result of a male and a female of biologically compatible species getting together with the goal of having a child." The autognome thought about this answer for a moment, then tilted her head.

"Then... where did I come from? I do not seem to have a place in that definition." E, who had been fiddling uncomfortably with a few mechanical pieces and wires on the floor nearby, stood up and rushed over, wrapping the autognome—herself not much smaller than the gnome—up in her arms.

"Oh, sweetie. You're the exception that proves the rule. All good rules need exceptions, right? No rule or definition can cover *everything* it needs to cover, which is why exceptions exist. They're unique and special, just. Like. You." E poked the autognome in the nose and let out a *boop*. "Even though you weren't made the normal way, you're still our daughter. *Amme* and I still came together and decided we wanted to have a child, we just had to do things a bit differently." Kira placed a hand on Aya's head and rubbed it reassuringly.

"Yes, yes. Listen to Mama. She's right *this* time." The elf giggled and flicked her wife's shoulder teasingly; E just rolled her eyes.

"Remember when *Amme* taught you about the Weave? How there's essentially an invisible, infinite tangle of magical energy weaving through and around everything? You see, *Amme* and I know all kinds of ways to interact with it. When we realized we wanted you, we built up a body for you with all our knowledge and love, grabbed some of the Weave, and wrapped it all through you, giving you life—just like any other baby, except we had to work much harder because we loved you *thaaaat* much."

Upon hearing that, Aya's eyes lit up. "When I get older, I want to be like Mama and *Amme*! You're so cool!" E's face flushed red again; Kira broke into a wide smile.

"Well, if that's the case, why wait? Interacting directly with the Weave might be a bit too hard for you right now, but Mama is much better at using all kinds of materials to interact with it. You might be able to help her with something really simple! And I'll be right here with you the entire time, helping you figure it out, too," Kira said, smile still on her face.

Over the next 10 minutes, E and Kira helped Aya mess around with some of the magical components around the lab, until eventually, the three of them had combined their efforts to make

a gear glow. E explained that some materials were better at channeling magic than others, one of which was used in the construction of that gear. Kira drew out and explained an example for Aya about how to create a special magic rune that could draw in the Weave once some energy was channeled through it; once Aya had recreated on the gear what Kira showed her, Kira channeled some of the Weave into the gear. The magical energies channeling through it, much like a lightbulb, caused it to glow almost as brightly as the smiles on the family's faces.